

Paul's Old Testament Story

Galatians 4:21-31

Small Group Bible Study Series

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Editor: The Gospel Vault

① TEXT	② DEVOTIONAL	③ COMMENTARY	④ SELF-STUDY GUIDE
Foundation	Personal prep	Teacher preparation	Group meeting
Everyone	All group members	Teacher / Leader	Small group

① BIBLICAL TEXT

NKJV · Galatians 4:21-31

21 *Tell me, you who desire to be under the law, do you not hear the law?*

22 *For it is written that Abraham had two sons: the one by a bondwoman, the other by a freewoman.*

23 *But he who was of the bondwoman was born according to the flesh, and he of the freewoman through promise,*

24 *which things are symbolic. For these are the two covenants: the one from Mount Sinai which gives birth to bondage, which is Hagar—*

25 *for this Hagar is Mount Sinai in Arabia, and corresponds to Jerusalem which now is, and is in bondage with her children—*

26 *but the Jerusalem above is free, which is the mother of us all.*

27 *For it is written: "Rejoice, O barren, you who do not bear! Break forth and shout, you who are not in labor! For the desolate has many more children than she who has a husband."*

28 *Now we, brethren, as Isaac was, are children of promise.*

29 *But, as he who was born according to the flesh then persecuted him who was born according to the Spirit, even so it is now.*

30 *Nevertheless what does the Scripture say? "Cast out the bondwoman and her son, for the son of the bondwoman shall not be heir with the son of the freewoman."*

31 *So then, brethren, we are not children of the bondwoman but of the free.*

② DEVOTIONAL

Personal preparation · All group members

"So then, brethren, we are not children of the bondwoman but of the free."

Paul tells a four-thousand-year-old family story to make a point that is anything but ancient: you cannot mix bondage and freedom, law and promise, flesh and Spirit, and expect to keep both. Two sons, two women, two mountains, two Jerusalems — every pair in this allegory lines up on one side or the other, and Paul is not shy about calling for a vote.

What makes it personal is that the two sides were never equally available to Abraham. Ishmael came from a plan Sarah devised, Abraham carried out, and no faith was required to pull off — a son anyone could arrange. Isaac came from a body "as good as dead" and a promise God alone could keep, twenty-five years after it was made, at an age calculated to remove any possible credit from human effort. One son represents what man can produce. The other represents what only God can give.

Every believer is, by that measure, an Isaac — born not of performance but of promise, not because anything in us made it happen but because God did exactly what He said He would, on His own timetable, for His own glory. The bondwoman's son will always resent the child of promise; the allegory does not end at Genesis. But Scripture's verdict is not ambiguous: cast out the bondwoman and her son. There is no mixing the two systems, only a choice of which one you belong to.

Reflect

1. Where might you still be operating like Abraham at eighty-two — trying to help God out with a plan of your own making rather than waiting on His promise?
2. Do you relate to God on the "work six days, then rest" pattern of law, or the "rest, then work" pattern of grace?
3. Is there a rule or requirement you've let functionally sit alongside faith in Christ, as if the two systems could be blended?

So then, brethren, we are not children of the bondwoman but of the free.

③ COMMENTARY

Teacher preparation resource · Full text organized under outline headings

Proposition: *Because Isaac, the child of promise, could never share an inheritance with Ishmael, the child of the flesh, the believer — born by the same kind of promise — must cast out every attempt to mix law-keeping with grace and stand only in the freedom to which Christ has called him.*

Introduction

The key to understanding this whole passage is the number two. Paul lines up two sons, Ishmael and Isaac; two women, the bondwoman Hagar and the free woman Sarah; two spheres, flesh and Spirit; two covenants, law and promise; two places, Arabia and Jerusalem; two mountains, Sinai and Zion; and two Jerusalems, earthly and heavenly. Think of it like the old black-and-white Western movies — the bad guy always wore a black hat, the good guy a white hat. The black hats go on the left: Ishmael, Hagar the bondwoman, flesh, the Mosaic covenant, Arabia, Mount Sinai, the earthly Jerusalem, bondage, the Judaizers. The white hats go on the right: Isaac, Sarah the freewoman, Spirit, the Abrahamic covenant of promise, Jerusalem, Mount Zion, the heavenly Jerusalem, freedom — and Paul. We are over here with Paul, under that whole right-hand column. That is exactly what he is trying to show the Galatians.

I. The Argument – 4:21

Signed Up Without Reading the Fine Print

"Tell me, you who desire to be under the law, do you not hear the law?"

First, Paul makes his argument. "Tell me, you who desire to be under the law, do you not hear the law?" That sounds strange — he chides them about the law, saying, in effect, you signed up for the law without even knowing what's in it. This sounds familiar — it sounds like "let's pass this legislation, and then we'll find out what's in it." Well, that's exactly what they did — they signed up for the legislation and didn't know what was in there, so Paul says, don't you know? Don't you hear what the law says? Why are you in that? Paul had, of course, read the entire law, had probably memorized some of it, most of it, and it appalled him that they would do such a thing — go back to the law. So Paul used many methods, all through Galatians, trying to get them not to go back to the law. And now he's going to try one more thing: "I'm going to tell you a story. You people don't understand it," he's telling the Galatians — "you don't understand anything, I'm going to take you back to kindergarten and let a storyteller tell you a story." Here's the story he tells: an allegory. A picture, after all, is worth a thousand words.

II. The Allegory – 4:22-27

A. Two Sons – 4:22

"For it is written that Abraham had two sons: the one by a bondwoman, the other by a freewoman."

We can learn Abraham's whole experience by watching the numbers, his age at each step. It starts at age seventy-five — Moses started at eighty, Abraham started at seventy-five, so maybe some of us should have started a long time ago too. Abraham was called from Ur of the Chaldees when he was seventy-five, and God promised him many things, and all of it hinged on one thing: a son. That's how you get a nation, that's how you get a land, that's how you get blessing — all riding on that one son. At eighty-two, when the son still wasn't born, Abraham thought, maybe it's Eliezer — born in my house, a servant, but born in my house, so that makes him my son, kind of — helping God out, you know, maybe God can't do it through me and Sarah, maybe He'll accept that. So he goes to God and says, how about him, let him be the one. God says no — this one shall not be your heir, the one who will come from your own body (Genesis 15:4). Reading this, it seems God gives him one piece of the puzzle at a time: first, someone legally his son, which is what Eliezer was; then one more piece is still withheld — no, it will come from your own body.

So at eighty-five, at Sarah's insistence and with God's permission, Abraham took Hagar and, as the custom of the day was, married her — Sarah's slave-handmaid — and soon she was expecting. Now he had "from my own body"; it really didn't matter who the mother was, so he went with Hagar. At eighty-six, before the child was born, tension arose between Sarah and Hagar — you can imagine that. Hagar might say to Sarah, okay, I'll fix your dresses, I'll cook your food — but I had the baby, you didn't, your husband came to me. My mother used to say, no house is large enough for two women — some have experienced that themselves. There was no way these two women could get along in the same house, so Sarah said, get her out of here. Abraham did, but then God brought Hagar back and told her to go back and be submissive to Sarah until the child was born. So at eighty-seven, Hagar gives birth to a son named Ishmael. Naturally, Hagar and Abraham think Ishmael will be the heir — of course, out of his own body, why not? And God says no — here's one more piece of the puzzle: Sarah, your wife, will bear you a son. What's wrong with you? It's going to be your son with Sarah. Now, stop trying to help God out — He's going to do exactly what He said.

Finally, at age one hundred, Isaac is born — twenty-five years later. Sarah was ninety, and she had been barren her whole life, and when God told Abraham, the year before, when he was only ninety-nine, Abraham said, "shall a child be born to a man who is one hundred years old? And shall Sarah, who is ninety years old, bear a child?" (Genesis 17:17). So finally, the promised seed was born (Genesis 21). There was never any problem with Abraham himself in all this — after all, didn't he already have a son in Ishmael? There didn't seem to be anything wrong with him. Later, Sarah died at one hundred twenty-seven, and Abraham, ten years older, was one hundred thirty-seven — and then he married again, to Keturah, and had six more sons: Zimran, Jokshan, Medan, Midian, Ishbak, and Shuah (no daughters are even mentioned, though there likely were some). Abraham died at age one hundred seventy-five. So there it is: Abraham had two sons — Ishmael through the flesh, and Isaac through the promise.

B. Two Systems – 4:23

"But he who was of the bondwoman was born according to the flesh, and he of the freewoman through promise,"

1. Ishmael Was Born of the Flesh. Paul is not speaking here about their different social positions, slave versus free, nor is he speaking about physical flesh in the literal sense — after all, both boys were physically born the ordinary way. He is speaking of the scheme by which Ishmael came about: selfish desires and human means, totally apart from the will of God. God permitted it, but it was never His will. It was devised by Sarah and carried out by Abraham and Hagar — no miracle was involved. Birth itself is always a miracle, but there was nothing special or miraculous about this one; it happens all the time. It represents man's way, what man himself can produce. Ishmael was a child of the flesh.

2. Isaac Was Born of the Promise. Isaac was born under entirely different circumstances — his parents were obeying God, not improvising around Him, and his birth was miraculous, according to God's own will. He was the child of faith. Paul describes exactly this kind of faith in Romans 4:19: "and not being weak in faith, he did not consider his own body, already dead (since he was about a hundred years old), and the deadness of Sarah's womb. He did not waver at the promise of God through unbelief, but was strengthened in faith, giving glory to God, and being fully convinced that what He had promised He was also able to perform. And therefore it was accounted to him for righteousness." Abraham simply believed God, doing exactly what God said, and so brought forth the child of promise, finally, after twenty-five years. Isaac was the child of promise.

C. Two Symbols – 4:24-27

So now we have two sons, and two systems — and now two symbols. I need to pause here and say a word about this word "allegory" — *allēgoroumena*. I read it in the Greek text as a passive: these things "have been made into an allegory." They were not allegorical to begin with — they happened, historically, in the Old Testament, exactly as recorded. But Paul is taking these historical events and turning them into an allegory, telling a story to make his point, using them as symbols even though they are also literal, historical fact.

1. The Covenant of Law – 4:24-25. "Which things are symbolic. For these are the two covenants: the one from Mount Sinai which gives birth to bondage, which is Hagar — for this Hagar is Mount Sinai in Arabia, and corresponds to Jerusalem which now is, and is in bondage with her children." So Paul lines up the works side — the left side. Mount Sinai, bondage, Hagar, Mount Sinai in Arabia — all of it goes on the left. The first covenant is from Sinai in Arabia; it gives birth to bondage; it is Hagar. Then he adds: Jerusalem, the earthly Jerusalem, which is now — that is, in Paul's own day — in bondage along with her children, and this includes the Judaizers. So Mount Sinai and the earthly Jerusalem, then as now, are symbols of law and slavery.

2. The Covenant of Liberty – 4:26-27. "But the Jerusalem above is free, which is the mother of us all. For it is written" — Isaiah 54:1 — "rejoice, O barren, you who do not bear! Break forth and shout, you who are not in labor! For the desolate has many more children than she who has a husband." All Paul is saying is that Sarah, though she was barren, now has many more children than Hagar does. The first covenant relates to Mount Sinai — Hebrews 12 gives a description of the law, the old earthly Jerusalem, and the new Jerusalem in heaven: "for you have not come to the mountain that may be touched and that burned with fire, and to blackness and darkness and tempest, and the sound of a trumpet and the voice of words, so that those

who heard it begged that the word should not be spoken to them anymore" — stop, it's too hard for us — "for they could not endure what was commanded: and if so much as a beast touches the mountain, it shall be stoned or shot with an arrow" — even a dumb animal wandering onto the mountain had to be killed, because it had no business being there — "and so terrifying was the sight that Moses said, I am exceedingly afraid and trembling" (Hebrews 12:18-21). I read once about a writer in England who said that Moses walked closer with the Almighty than almost anyone — followed Him through plague after plague, through the Red Sea and everything else — but when he got to Mount Sinai, even Moses said, I was scared to death. That's the first mountain. Would you want that one? Or would you rather have Mount Zion — not Sinai, Zion?

"But you have come to Mount Zion and to the city of the living God, the heavenly Jerusalem, to an innumerable company of angels, to the general assembly and church of the firstborn who are registered in heaven, to God the Judge of all, to the spirits of just men made perfect, to Jesus the Mediator of the new covenant, and to the blood of sprinkling that speaks better things than that of Abel" (Hebrews 12:22-24). That is not much of a decision to make — it is, as it were, a slam dunk. So Paul lines up the grace side, the right side: Sarah, Mount Zion, the heavenly Jerusalem — the destiny of all believers, which will one day come down to earth (Revelation 21:2-3) and cover the earth with His righteousness. Paul is ready now to call for the vote. All right, Galatians — which side are you going to choose, the earthly Jerusalem or the heavenly Jerusalem? It hardly seems like much of a decision. So we're ready for the application.

III. The Application – 4:28-31

A. We Are Children of Promise – 4:28

"Now we, brethren, as Isaac was, are children of promise."

There is no doubt about how Isaac was born — God waited twenty-five years so there could be no possible question about it. Make it as hard as it can possibly be, so that when it happens, everyone will know God did it — that's why God sometimes gives us seemingly impossible assignments. After you've struggled at a church for twelve years and nothing happens, and then, finally, a miracle happens and it begins to grow — who did that? You, after twelve years of doing essentially nothing yourself? No — it must be God, and that's fine, I'll bow to that, I do it all the time. There's no doubt about who did it; it was a miracle, not based on performance, but based on the promise of God. So it is with us. How were we born again — by faith, or by some work of the law? Of course not; the law had nothing to do with it. Our new birth was every bit as much a miracle as Isaac's birth was. We are children of the promise, exactly as Isaac was.

B. We Are Candidates for Persecution – 4:29

"But, as he who was born according to the flesh then persecuted him who was born according to the Spirit, even so it is now."

Hagar persecuted Sarah — she taunted her, because Sarah's husband had come to her to fulfill his greatest hope. Ishmael, in turn, hated Isaac; Isaac got all the attention, and had replaced him as heir. The phrase "even so it is now" can be applied at least three ways.

1. Historically. The hatred between the Arabs and the Israelites has its beginning in Genesis, some four thousand years ago, and it continues to this day. It will not matter what the United

Nations decides about statehood — that ruling will not change the underlying hatred one bit. It will not stop until Jesus returns, judges the world, and establishes His rule of righteousness in the millennium. That is when, and only when, it will finally stop.

2. Religiously. Remember, Paul was once a persecutor of the church — some of them died because of his persecution — and then he believed, and became persecuted himself by those very same kind of people, who even tried to kill him many times. The church has trouble today with legalists too — sometimes from those who insist on keeping at least part of the Mosaic law, and, notably, they get to decide which parts. But the law is a unit — it came in as a unit and went out as a unit at the cross; you cannot separate it and keep parts here and parts there, the law as a whole stands or falls together. More likely, though, we get our persecution from legalists who make up their own laws and rules according to what they decide God's people ought or ought not to be doing. It isn't the tradition of the elders anymore, but the tradition of the Baptists — they say you have to do this and this and this — or the Presbyterians say you have to do that. Whatever it is, it's their own rules, and you're expected to do what they say, because what they say goes.

3. Spiritually. This one gets closer to home — get ready. Paul is contrasting, in his allegory, flesh and Spirit — chapter 5 will talk more about this, and we will too. "For the flesh lusts against the Spirit, and the Spirit against the flesh; and these are contrary to one another, so that you do not do the things that you wish" (Galatians 5:17). This is not a reference to the "dirty dozen" — you know, we don't smoke, drink, or chew, and we don't go with the girls who do, none of that. Chapter 5 lists obvious sins — adultery, fornication, uncleanness, lewdness, idolatry, sorcery, murders, drunkenness, revelries. Well, we don't do those things. But that isn't the end of the list — it continues: hatred, contentions, jealousies, outbursts of wrath, selfish ambitions, dissensions, heresies, envy. A little closer to home now. The fight goes on, but not out there, not out here — in here. And we're not going to change anything out there or out here until we change what's in here. So if we're going to win that battle, we have to depend on the Spirit — the Spirit lusts against the flesh, flesh against the Spirit. God gave us the Holy Spirit to tell us what to do; we had a conscience before, but now we have an enlivened conscience, the Holy Spirit Himself, and He tells us what to do, and we have to depend on Him. I find out what's wrong, I know what's wrong to do, and I say, wait a minute, should I or shouldn't I — the Holy Spirit says no, you should not, don't do that. Then what happens? My flesh says, well, I've got to do this — and if I don't depend on the Spirit, Satan gets a foothold, and I lose, the church loses, the church at large loses. Salvation comes from depending on the Son; sanctification comes from depending on the Holy Spirit.

C. We Are Not to Compromise with the Flesh – 4:30

"Nevertheless what does the Scripture say? 'Cast out the bondwoman and her son, for the son of the bondwoman shall not be heir with the son of the freewoman.'"

This is where Paul has been heading the whole time — what is the answer to legalism? Scripture says, cast out the bondwoman and her son. Cast out the entire left-hand column of the allegory; none of it can be mixed with what is on the right side. What do we do with the Judaizers and their law — the Ten Commandments, the six hundred thirteen commandments, and everything the rabbis have piled on top of it since? Cast it out. It has no place in the life of the believer, or in the life of the believer's church — and none of it can be selectively kept either;

you don't get to pick the parts of that left column you happen to like and mix them in with grace. There's no place for that kind of mixture, for those sins, or for anything the church itself has added or substituted as a rule for deciding who counts as one of God's people.

D. We Are Called to Liberty – 4:31

"So then, brethren, we are not children of the bondwoman but of the free."

We are children of Sarah — the right side, freedom — not of Hagar, the left side, bondage. Have you ever noticed the difference between law and grace in how each treats a day of rest? Under the law, you work six days, and then you rest — you earn the rest, you work so that you may be blessed. Under grace, we rest, and then we work — we are already blessed, so we work. They work for the blessing; we work from the blessing. That is the whole picture Paul has been laying out this entire passage: throw out the bondwoman, throw out the rules and regulations that claim to identify who the true believers are and who they are not. We are not under law. We are under grace.

Conclusion

Two sons, two women, two covenants, two mountains, two Jerusalems — and only one column any believer can actually stand in. Isaac was never born by human effort, only by God's promise kept on God's timetable; every believer since has been born the same way. The allegory ends the same place the whole epistle does: cast out the bondwoman, refuse every mixture of law and grace, and stand in the liberty that is already yours by promise, not performance.

Lord, thank You.

④ SELF-STUDY GUIDE

For use during the group meeting · Focused on the commentary text

Greek Word Study

Verse	Greek Word / English	Strong's # / Translit. / Form	Definition & Significance
v.22-23	παιδίσκης <i>bondwoman</i> (maidservant)	G3814 <i>paidiskēs</i> N-GFS (Gen. Fem. Sg.)	STR: a girl, specially, a female slave or servant. THAY: a young female slave or maidservant, emphasizing servile status. Significance: Hagar is never named "wife" in this allegory's vocabulary — she remains, by this term, permanently in the category of bondage, standing for the entire system of law-keeping Paul places on the left side.
v.22-23	ἐλευθέρας <i>freewoman</i>	G1658 <i>eleutheras</i> Adj-GFS (Gen. Fem. Sg.)	STR: unrestrained, not a slave, exempt from obligation. THAY: free-born status; ethically, free from the yoke of the Mosaic law and the bondage of sin. Significance: Sarah's status as eleuthera, not her personal virtue, is the point of contrast Paul draws — the allegory turns on legal status (bondage vs. freedom), not on the character of either woman.
v.23,28	ἐπαγγελίας <i>promise</i>	G1860 <i>epangelias</i> N-GFS (Gen. Fem. Sg.)	STR: an announcement, especially a divine assurance of good. THAY: a pledge given, or the promised blessing itself. Significance: Isaac's birth "through promise" and believers as "children of promise" (v.28) use the identical term — the whole allegory hinges on this one word as the alternative to human effort or law-keeping.
v.24	ἀλληγορούμενα <i>symbolic (allegorized)</i>	G238 <i>allēgoroumena</i> V-PPM/P-NNP (Pres. Ptc. Mid./Pass. Nom. Neut. Pl.)	STR: to allegorize, be an allegory. THAY: to speak one thing in words while conveying another in sense. Significance: the passive participle ("having been allegorized") signals that Paul is not claiming these Genesis events were fictional or non-historical — they happened — but that he is now using them, after the fact, as a teaching allegory. The only NT occurrence of this word.
v.24	δουλείαν <i>bondage</i>	G1397 <i>douleian</i> N-AFS (Acc.)	STR: slavery, ceremonially or figuratively. THAY: the condition of a slave; used elsewhere of the fear produced by adherence to the Mosaic law (Rom. 8:15)

Verse	Greek Word / English	Strong's # / Translit. / Form	Definition & Significance
		Fem. Sg.)	and the burdensome system of religious obligation under law (Gal. 4:24; 5:1). Significance: the Sinai covenant "gives birth to" bondage as its natural offspring — law-keeping as a system for relating to God inherently produces slavery, never sonship.
v.24	γεννώσα <i>gives birth (bearing)</i>	G1080 <i>gennōsa</i> V-PPA-NFS (Pres. Ptc. Act. Nom. Fem. Sg.)	STR: to procreate, of father or mother; figuratively, to regenerate. THAY: to beget or bear; metaphorically, to cause to arise. Significance: Mount Sinai/Hagar is personified as continually "bearing" children into bondage — a present participle depicting the law's ongoing, natural offspring, in deliberate parallel to the New Testament's language of being "born" of the Spirit.
v.25	συστοιχεῖ <i>corresponds to</i>	G4960 <i>systoichei</i> V-PIA-3S (Pres. Ind. Act. 3rd Sg.)	STR: to file together, as soldiers in ranks; figuratively, to correspond to, answer to. THAY: to stand in the same row with, to be parallel with — used of an OT type matching its NT antitype. Significance: the only NT occurrence — a military image of ranks lined up together, exactly matching the outline's "black hats/white hats" columns: Sinai and the earthly Jerusalem stand in the very same file.
v.26	ἄνω <i>above</i>	G507 <i>anō</i> Adv (Adverb)	STR: upward, on the top. THAY: in a higher place, spatially above (as opposed to below); of things pertaining to heaven. Significance: "the Jerusalem above" stands in deliberate spatial and covenantal contrast to the earthly Jerusalem "which now is" (v.25) — the heavenly city is the present possession and future hope of every believer, Jew or Gentile.
v.27	στεῖρα <i>barren</i>	G4723 <i>steira</i> N-VFS (Voc. Fem. Sg.)	STR: sterile. THAY: literally hard or stiff; figuratively, a woman who does not conceive. Significance: quoting Isaiah 54:1, Paul applies "barren" to Sarah and, by extension, to the Jerusalem above — what looked hopeless and fruitless (barrenness) becomes, by God's promise, more fruitful than what looked naturally productive (Hagar's ordinary fertility).

Verse	Greek Word / English	Strong's # / Translit. / Form	Definition & Significance
v.29	ἐδίωκεν <i>persecuted</i>	G1377 <i>ediōken</i> V-IIA-3S (Imperf. Ind. Act. 3rd Sg.)	STR: to pursue, by implication, to persecute. THAY: to harass, molest, or persecute another. Significance: the imperfect tense pictures ongoing, repeated harassment, not a single incident — Ishmael's mockery of Isaac (Gen. 21:9) is treated by Paul as the pattern for how law-based religion will always, continually, treat those who live by promise.
v.30	Ἔκβαλε <i>cast out</i>	G1544 <i>ekbale</i> V-AAM-2S (Aor. Impv. Act. 2nd Sg.)	STR: to eject, literally or figuratively. THAY: to drive out or expel, often with the notion of decisive force. Significance: a sharp aorist imperative, quoting Sarah's own demand in Genesis 21:10 as authoritative Scripture — Paul treats this not as Sarah's jealousy but as God's own verdict on any attempt to mix law and grace.
v.30	κληρονομήσει <i>shall be heir (inherit)</i>	G2816 <i>klēronomēsei</i> V-FIA-3S (Fut. Ind. Act. 3rd Sg.)	STR: to be an heir to, literally or figuratively. THAY: to receive as an inheritance, to obtain by right of inheritance. Significance: the future tense states a settled, permanent fact — the son of the bondwoman categorically will not share the inheritance with the son of the freewoman; law-keeping and promise cannot jointly inherit the same blessing.

Cases: Nom. · Gen. · Dat. · Acc. · Voc. | Number: Sg. · Pl. | Gender: Masc. · Fem. · Neut. | Verb Mood: Ind. · Impv. · Subj. · Opt. · Inf. · Ptc. | Tense: Pres. · Imperf. · Fut. · Aor. · Perf. · Plpf. | Voice: Act. · Mid. · Pass. | Person: 1st/2nd/3rd Sg./Pl.

Study Questions

Part 1 — From the Commentary

Question	Answer
Why does Paul say the Galatians "do not hear the law" even though they desire to be under it (4:21)?	They had embraced law-keeping as a system without actually reckoning with what the law demands or produces — much like signing up for legislation before reading what is actually in it.
Why does Paul insist Ishmael's birth involved "no miracle," while Isaac's did?	Ishmael was the product of a plan Sarah devised and Abraham and Hagar carried out by ordinary human means, apart from God's revealed will; Isaac was born to parents obeying God, against

Question	Answer
	all natural possibility, exactly as and when God had promised.
What does Paul mean by calling these historical events "symbolic" or "allegorized" (4:24)?	The events themselves were literal history, not fiction; Paul is using them, after the fact, as a teaching allegory to illustrate the difference between the covenant of law and the covenant of promise.
How does Paul use Isaiah 54:1 to describe the Jerusalem above (4:27)?	He applies the promise to the barren woman who will have "many more children than she who has a husband" — Sarah, and the heavenly Jerusalem she represents, will prove far more fruitful than the natural fruitfulness of Hagar and the earthly system.
Why does Paul conclude with the command to "cast out the bondwoman and her son" (4:30) rather than simply urging tolerance of both views?	Because law and promise cannot jointly inherit the same blessing — the whole point of the allegory is that these two systems cannot be blended, so Paul calls for a clean and complete break with legalism, not a compromise between the two.

Part 2 — Study Questions

1. Paul spends four verses tracing Abraham's age at each step toward Isaac's birth. Why does that timeline matter to his argument?

Leader note: See Commentary II.A — the twenty-five-year gap that removed any possible credit from human effort.

2. Where have you, like Abraham at eighty-two, been tempted to "help God out" with a plan of your own rather than waiting on His promise?

Leader note: See Commentary II.A and II.B.1 — Ishmael as a child of the flesh, born of human scheming.

3. Paul says the Jerusalem above "is the mother of us all." What does it mean practically to live as a citizen of that city rather than the earthly one?

Leader note: See Commentary II.C.2 — the Mount Sinai/Mount Zion contrast from Hebrews 12.

4. Which of the three applications of "persecution" (historical, religious, spiritual) feels most present in your own life right now?

Leader note: See Commentary III.B.1-3.

5. What would it look like concretely to "cast out" a legalistic rule or requirement you've let sit alongside your faith in Christ?

Leader note: See Commentary III.C-D — the no-mixture principle and the rest-then-work pattern of grace.

Part 3 — Passage Summary

Verse(s)	Theme	Key Truth
4:21	The Argument	The Galatians desire the law without understanding what it actually says or requires.
4:22-27	The Allegory	Two sons, two systems, two symbols: Ishmael/flesh/Sinai/bondage on one side, Isaac/promise/Zion/freedom on the other.
4:28-31	The Application	Believers are children of promise, should expect persecution from the flesh, must not compromise with legalism, and are called to liberty.

⑤ APPLICATION

Closes the study · Personal & corporate

1. Stop Helping God Out

Scripture: *Galatians 4:22-23*

Drawn from Commentary II.A-B.

Ishmael came from Abraham and Sarah's own plan to accomplish God's promise by human means. Isaac came from simply waiting on God to do what only He could do, in His own timing.

Reflection: *Is there a promise or calling of God in your life where you've been tempted to "help Him out" with your own scheme rather than trusting His timing?*

Practical Step: Name that situation specifically, and this week, take one deliberate step of simply waiting rather than engineering the outcome yourself.

2. Know Which Column You're In

Scripture: *Galatians 4:24-27*

Drawn from Commentary II.C.

Every element of Paul's allegory lines up on one of two sides — there is no third column, and nothing from the bondage side can be mixed into the freedom side.

Reflection: *Is there a rule, requirement, or performance standard you've quietly moved from the "law" column into your walk of grace?*

Practical Step: Identify that one item this week and consciously set it back where it belongs — outside your standing with God, not a condition of it.

3. Expect the Ishmaels

Scripture: *Galatians 4:29*

Drawn from Commentary III.B and FGR (Charles Ryrie, Balancing the Christian Life).

Those who live by the flesh — whether historically, religiously, or in the quieter spiritual sense of hatred, envy, and selfish ambition — will resent and oppose those who live by promise. Paul treats this as the expected pattern, not the exception.

Reflection: *Where have you experienced resentment or opposition simply for trusting grace rather than earning approval through performance?*

Practical Step: Rather than being surprised by that opposition this week, prepare for it — and respond the way a child of promise can afford to: without needing to win the argument.

4. Work From the Blessing, Not For It

Scripture: *Galatians 4:30-31*

Drawn from Commentary III.D.

Under law, you work six days and then rest, earning what follows. Under grace, you rest first, already blessed, and then you work — from the blessing rather than for it.

Reflection: *This week, are you approaching your service to God as a way of earning His blessing, or as a response to the blessing you already have in Christ?*

Practical Step: Choose one act of service this week and deliberately do it from rest and gratitude rather than from a sense of obligation to earn favor.

End of Study · Galatians 4:21-31